

ENGL 158: COMMUNICATION SKILLS II

Lecture 3: Writing As A Process

Some Approaches to Writing

- Product approach
- Genre approach
- Process approach

The Process Approach

- The Process Approach aims to reflect what **real writers** do in **real situations**.
- It considers writing as **non-linear**

Views on Process Approach to Writing 1

“Good writing does not just happen. The best writers spend a great deal of time thinking, planning, rewriting, and editing.”



– Elizabeth West

Views on Process Approach to Writing 2

- Writing is messy, recursive, convoluted, and uneven. Writers write, plan, revise, anticipate, and review throughout the writing process, moving back and forth.
- The process approach appeals to ‘common sense’ and many life activities such as cooking, sweeping, dressing, and even vocations sewing, carpentry, painting, etc.
- The motto of the Process Approach is: *Writing is rewriting.*
- The process approach focuses on the steps involved in creating a piece of work.

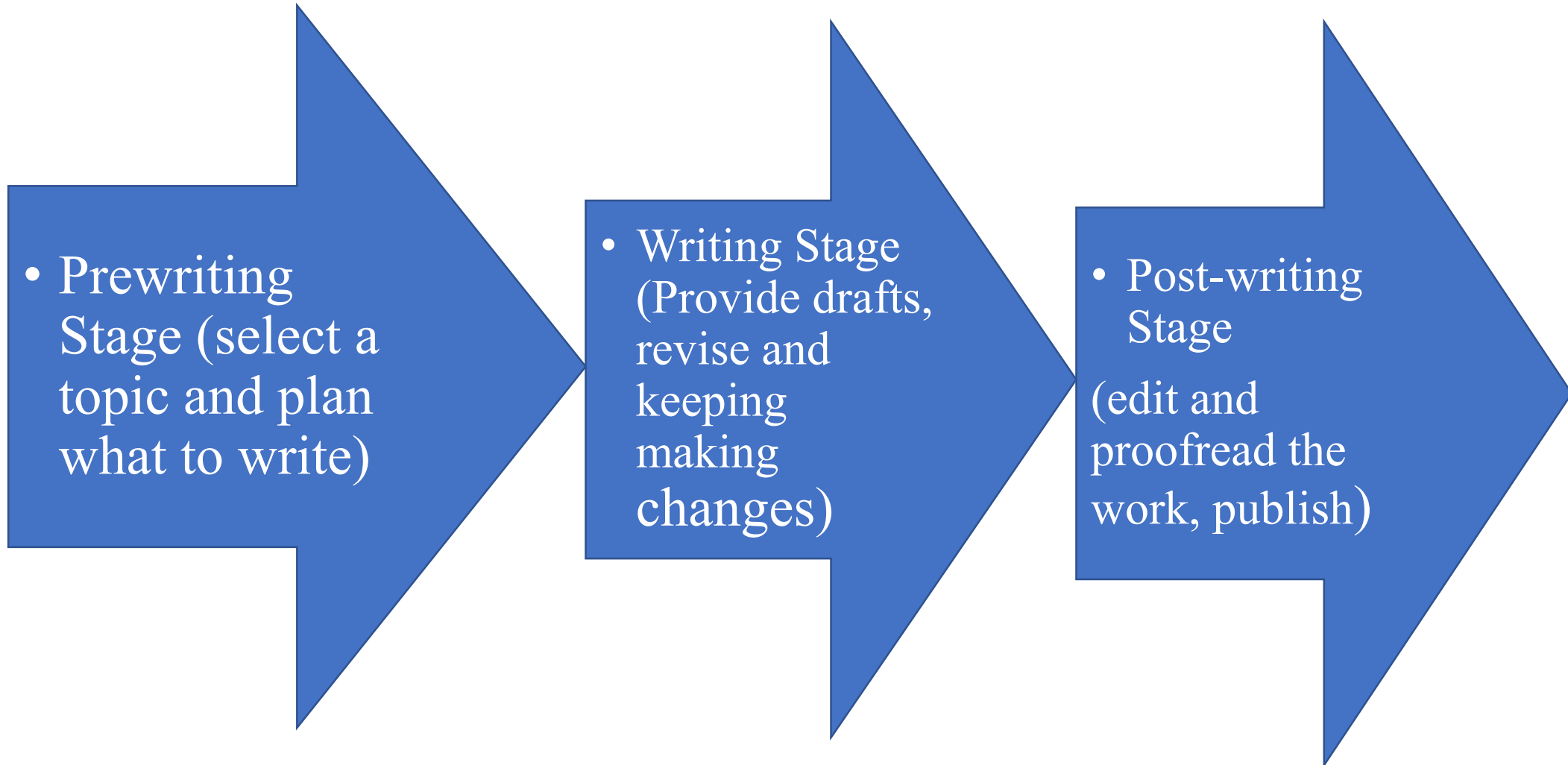
Views on Process Approach to Writing 3

- Good writers organise, plan, and re-write *throughout* the writing process, changing things lots of times if necessary, and writing multiple drafts.
- Good writers may rehearse or discuss what they want to write before they actually do it.
- Good writers read their writing carefully, trying to imagine how clear their ideas are to a reader. If something is not clear, they change it.
- Writing is a process which requires several identifiable steps.

What the Process Approach emphasizes

1. The importance of writing multiple drafts
2. The importance of revision
3. The importance of planning throughout
4. The importance of making your writing reader-friendly
5. The importance of writing in different styles for different audiences

Stages/Steps in Process Approach 1



Stages/Steps in Process Approach 2



THE PRE-WRITING STAGE

Sub-steps in the pre-writing:

Define your audience (audience analysis) 1

Know the audience you are writing to:

- Gender
- Age
- Status
- Religion
- Educational background
- Nationality
- Belief systems/ideology

Sub-steps in the pre-writing:

Topic selection 2

Factors to Consider in Selecting a topic.

- Relevance
- Availability of resources
- Availability of information
- Accessibility of information
- Personal interest
- Strength or competence
- Duration (time assigned)
- Length of the work

NB: The topic should not be too narrow nor too broad.

After selecting the topic, what next?

The Vice Chancellor, as part of her “Motivating-Students-to-Excel Agenda” has donated GhS20,000.00 to this class. What must we use the money for?

Students' Activity: Let's Generate Ideas

- 1.
- 2.
- 3.
- 4.
- 5.
- 6.
- 7.
- 8.
- 9.
- 10.
- Etc.

Sub-steps in the pre-writing: Brainstorming 3

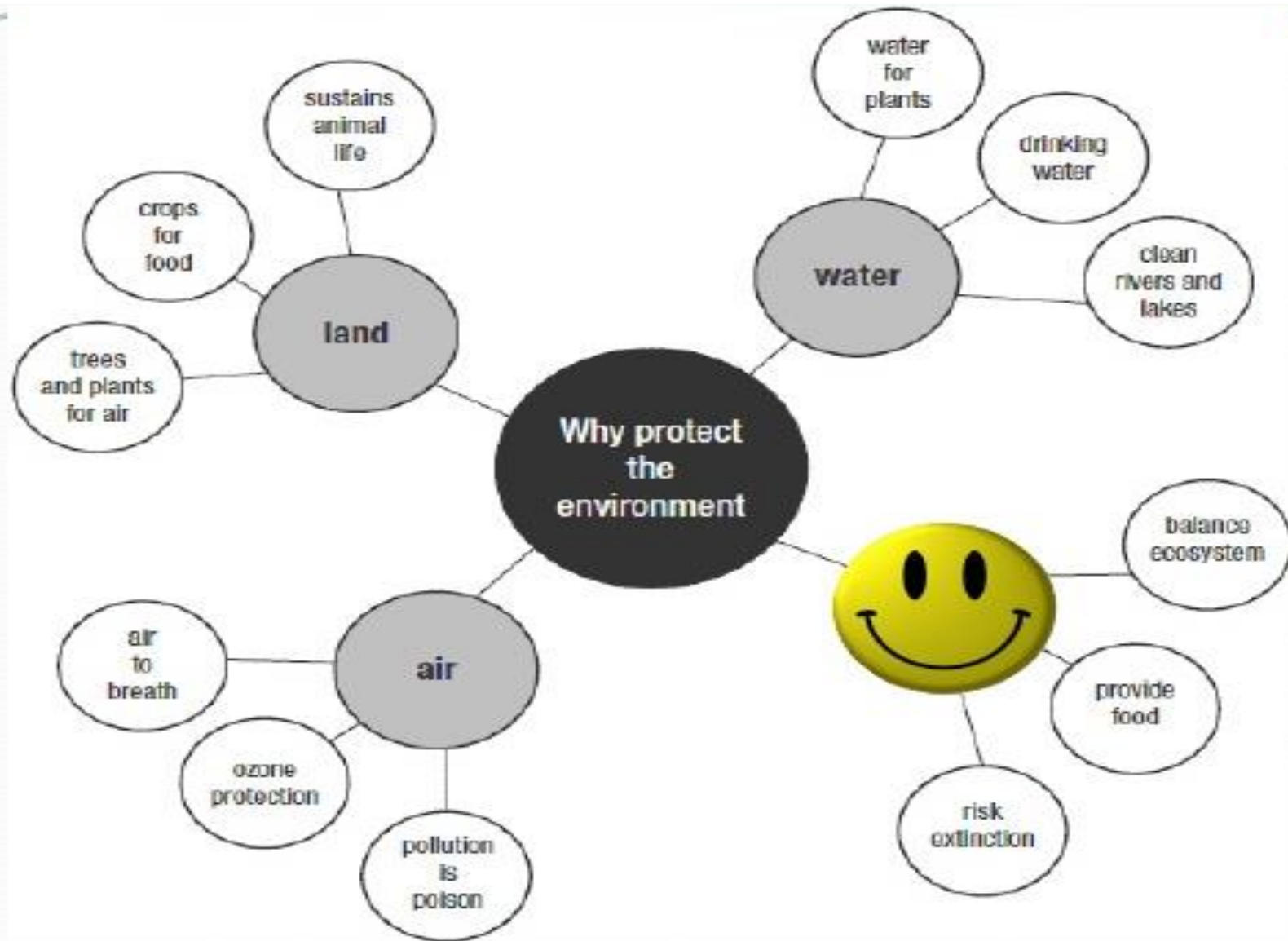
- Brainstorming is a creativity technique by which efforts are made to gather a list of ideas spontaneously.
- People are able to think more freely and they suggest as many spontaneous new ideas as possible. All the ideas are noted down without criticism and after the brainstorming session the ideas are evaluated.

Rules Underpinning Brainstorming

- **Go for quantity:** This rule is a means of enhancing divergent production, aiming at facilitation of problem solution through the maxim *quantity breeds quality*.
- **Withhold criticism:** Criticism of ideas generated should be put 'on hold'. Focus on extending or adding to ideas. Reserve criticism for a later 'critical stage' of the process.
- **Welcome wild ideas:** To get a good long list of suggestions, wild ideas are encouraged. They can be generated by looking at new perspectives and suspending assumptions.
- **Combine and improve ideas:** Build ideas by a process of association/clustering.

Sub-steps in the pre-writing: Clustering 4

- Clustering is a way of narrowing your thoughts by classifying related ideas.
- Cluster analysis or clustering is the task of grouping ideas such that those in the same group are more similar to each other than to those in other groups.
- **See the next slide**



Sub-steps in the pre-writing: Outlining 5

- An outline is a way of organising *key ideas*
- An outline helps to set up an essay or a research paper
- An outline is a tool to help revise an essay or research paper.
- An outline can be a study tool to help you summarise *key ideas* in reading

Outlining

- It is the skeleton of the main points or ideas of an already written essay, or a yet-to-be-written essay
- **Types:** formal and informal



THE FORMAL OUTLINE

- A formal outline shows, in logical order, what you will be writing about.
- A formal outline helps you separate main ideas and supporting ideas.
- A formal outline gives you a foundation from which to build an introduction, a body, and a conclusion.
- A formal outline often changes after you write your first draft. It will show you where you need to add more research or make other changes.

Principles of Outlining

- Heading
- Labeling (numbering) NB: **Ideas of the same rank are given the same label.**
- Structuring (topic or sentence forms)

Addressing Immigration Challenges

I Introduction

- * Criteria for immigration
 - A. Political refugees
 - B. Relatives of citizens
 - C. Other applications

II. Screening Criteria

1. Medical Screening
2. Interview
3. Psychological screening
4. Background check

III. Students

1. Purpose of study
2. Commitment to study
 - A. How long will they stay?
 - B. How will they finance their education and support themselves?
3. Value to our educational system

IV. Government oversight

1. Obligation to have periodic checks on immigrants and students
2. Reporting any legal violations or suspicious behavior
3. The government needs to limit the number of immigrants

V. Conclusion

THE WRITING STAGE

1. Freewriting on the developed outline
(No focus on grammar and language)
2. Produce a draft
3. Revise the drafts several times for
clarity in presentation of ideas

Post-writing Stage: Editing & Proofreading

TYPES OF EDITING

- Self-editing
- Peer-editing
- Group-editing

The State Protocol Department has denied claims by the founder of the Ghana Freedom Party (GFP), Madam Akua Donkor that they have been given express instructions not to invite her and Dr Hassan Ayariga to state functions. Madam Akua Donkor disclosed that she does not receive invites as she used to and in an attempt to find out from the State Protocol Department (SPD), she was told by one Mensah that her name is not among persons to be invited for such events as directed by the presidency. Akua Donkor believes the current President, Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo despises not only her but Dr Hassan Ayariga of the **All Peoples Congress (NDC)** for which reason they have both been relegated to the background. “Nana Addo does not like me and Hassan Ayariga. I am sure that is why he has directed them not invite me for state functions but I don’t care”, he revealed on Kumasi-based Abusua Fm. But Deputy Chief Protocol Officer at the State protocol department Nana Mensah refuted claims that he refused to give her invite adding that the President had no hand in the protocol list...

FOCUS OF EDITING: CONTENT 1

- Relevance
- Adequacy
- Consistency
- Accuracy

FOCUS OF EDITING: STRUCTURE **2**

- Generic requirements (letter, memo, abstract, etc.)
- Well-organized (introduction, developing paragraphs, and concluding paragraphs)
- Logical sequencing
- Transitional markers

FOCUS OF EDITING: CLARITY 3

At word, phrase, clausal, and sentence levels

- Ambiguity and vagueness
- Dangling or misrelated constructions
- Sentence fragments and run-on sentences
- Awkward sentences
- Inappropriate lexical choices

FOCUS OF EDITING: STYLE

4

- Level of formality
- Appropriate tone
- Sentence beginning, length, variety, and complexity
- Paragraph length
- Gender-sensitive language
- Nominalized
- Verbalized

N.B. Many factors affect style: aim, audience, and topic

FOCUS OF EDITING: FORMATTING 5

- Lecturer's/department's/institution's guidelines
- Spacing, font size, font type,
- Margins
- Bold, italics, underlining
- Pagination
- Table, figure, and chart
- References/Bibliography
- Word limit

FOCUS OF EDITING: CONCISENESS 6

- Replace several vague words with specific words
- Adopt effective sentence combining practices
- Replace a phrase with a word
- Dispense with words that have very little utility value: ‘actually’, ‘basically’, ‘practically’
- Avoid redundancies: ‘basic fundamentals’, ‘free gift’, ‘large in size’, ‘round in shape’

PROOFREADING

- This may be termed surface revision. It largely focuses on the mechanics of the language use.

FOCUS OF PROOREADING

1. Concord
2. Spelling
3. Punctuation
4. Tense
5. Repetition of words (e.g. Africans must be be patriotic)

SOME GUIDELINES FOR EDITING/PROOFREADING

- Maintain some distance from the text in terms of time (thus, allow the work to *simmer*)
- Decide what medium allows you to edit most carefully
- Find a quiet place
- Edit and proofread in several short blocks of time, rather than all at once